

MIRROR PAGE

A comic-strip light-routing puzzle where an unreliable narrator twists the rules. • TGC Game Jam 2026 Proposal

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IndieConnect ID	[YOUR_INDIECONNECT_ID]	Public GitHub	github.com/SankeerthNara/TGC-Game-Jam (MIT)
Themes (All 3)	COMIC TWIST LIGHT	Target Playtime	12 – 15 mins first playthrough (20 min hard cap)
Engine & Renderer	Godot 4.7, GDScript only, GL Compatibility Renderer (Web/HTML5 export hosted on itch.io)		

1. PITCH & CORE CONCEPT

Gutter Town has gone dark. You play a small caped comic hero carrying a torch. Walk the seamless town with the arrow keys, find **hidden items** that glint in the dark, and trade them at the shop for **keys**. Each key opens a **page door** into a light puzzle: a comic page of swappable panels where you **drag panels** and **flip mirrors** to steer a beam onto the stars. Solving a page lights its district. An unreliable narrator rewrites the rules, and cheap lookalike keys can open the **wrong door**, dropping you into a page from some other comic.

2. INTEGRATION OF THE THREE THEMES

Theme	How It Drives Gameplay & Narrative
Comic	The town is a comic world (ink outlines, halftone paper, narrator captions, onomatopoeia like WHOOSH and ZAP) and every puzzle is a comic page whose panels are movable tiles; gutters act as light refractors.
Light	The town is dark: your torch, street lamps and braziers push the dark back, and solving a page switches its district's lights on. The puzzles are all about steering a beam off mirrors onto star targets.
Twist	(1) <i>Goal Twist (Page 3)</i> : the hero you were lighting is the villain; targets swap roles and you re-solve. (2) <i>Rule Twists (Pages 4–6)</i> : mirrors lie, gutters bend light 90°. (3) <i>Wrong Key, Wrong Door</i> : lookalike keys open decoy pages from other comics until the narrator admits the mistake.

3. CORE MECHANICS

- **Explore & Collect**: Pokemon-style walking in one seamless map. 37 hidden items (ink drops, gears, star shards) glint in the dark.
- **Trade for Keys**: At the shop, items buy keys. Each key has a shape that must match a door's keyhole; cheap lookalikes open decoy pages.
- **Panel Drag-Swap & Mirror Toggle**: drag panels to swap them (their contents move too), click mirrors to flip them. Locked panels add constraints.
- **Beam Tracing**: an instant headless raycast lights targets and flags hazards after every move.
- **Frictionless Undo / Reset**: [Z] undo, [R] reset, [M] back to the map; no softlocks.

4. THE NARRATOR'S RULE TWISTS

Rule	Mechanical Impact	Introduced
Normal	Standard optical reflections: mirrors reflect as drawn; gutters maintain beam angle.	Levels 1, 2, 3
Goal Flip	Narrator caption flips polarity: good stars become toxic; hazards (red X) become the required target.	Levels 3 and 6
Lying Mirrors	Mirrors reflect the exact opposite of their drawn slant (slashes act as backslashes).	Level 4
Gutter Bend	Crossing a panel gutter forces a mandatory 90° clockwise beam deflection on the entry cell.	Levels 5 and 6

5. CONTENT PLAN & GAMEPLAY LOOP (15 MINUTES)

#	Level Name	Core Mechanic / Rule Introduced	Target Time
1	Page One (plaza)	Panel swapping across gutters to carry a straight beam to the hero's star.	1.5 min
2	Looking Glass	Combining panel swapping with mirror angle toggles and wall obstacles.	2.5 min
3	The Twist	Goal Flip Twist: Solves normally, narrator flips roles, re-solve page for villain.	2.5 min
4	Liar, Liar	Lying Mirrors: Slashes reflect counter-intuitively; mental inversion puzzle.	2.5 min
5	Gutter Bend	Gutter Bend: Beams turn 90° at boundaries; locked panels limit swap freedom.	3.0 min
6	The Last Page	Grand Finale: Combines lying mirrors, gutter bends, locked tiles, and final flip.	3.0 min

Town loop: explore → find items → trade for the right key → open a door → solve the page → district lights up → narrator reacts. Four districts, four ink-gates, two wrong-key decoy pages.

6. SCOPE BOUNDARIES

In Scope: walkable lit town with torch, hidden items, trade shop, keys and locked doors, wrong-key decoy pages, 6 tuned puzzle pages, 3 rule mutations, goal flip twist, narrator caption UI, menus, end screen, comic sound effects, music, web export.
Out of Scope (Strictly Cut): Level editor, save slots, mobile touch, gamepads, side quests, more than 6 real pages.

7. TECHNICAL ARCHITECTURE & WEB FEASIBILITY

- **Engine & Renderer:** Godot 4.7 with GL Compatibility renderer; single-threaded Web export with zero native extensions or GDExtensions.
- **Model-View Decoupling:** pure GDScript puzzle model (PageModel, BeamSolver) separate from rendering; the town (World) is data-driven from a JSON map. Tested headless.
- **Automated Validation:** Built-in BFS/DFS solver (level_check.gd) verifies every level is 100% solvable within 2–8 optimal moves.
- **Web Export:** game package under 1 MB PCK (build about 38 MB uncompressed, ~8 MB gzip). 2D lights and darkness verified in a browser build with 0 console errors.

8. 100-HOUR DEVELOPMENT MILESTONES

Hours	Phase & Deliverables	Current Status
0 – 12	Concept lock, core engine prototype, level format, art research, proposal submission.	COMPLETE
12 – 30	Vertical slice: town, shop and keys, comic UI (HUD, caption, pause), first art pass, CC0 audio, pages 1–6 playable.	IN PROGRESS
30 – 60	Town polish, more props and lights, sound and music integration, difficulty tuning from playtests.	Planned
60 – 85	Balancing, narrative comedic timing, web playtests, UI juice (panel shake, onomatopoeia).	Planned
85 – 100	Feature freeze at Hour 85. Web export audit, itch.io upload, README and CREDITS audit.	Planned

9. ASSETS & AI DISCLOSURE

- **Asset Rule Compliance:** Zero paid assets. All assets are 100% free, CC0, or open source with full attribution in CREDITS.md:
 - **Fonts:** **Bangers** (SIL OFL 1.1) and **Comic Neue** (SIL OFL 1.1) from Google Fonts.
 - **Audio:** Procedural CC0 synthesized sound effects and jazz loop generated in Python.
 - **Art & Textures:** Vintage newsprint textures, Ben-Day halftone dots, and comic burst badges generated procedurally.
- **AI Collaboration:** All AI usage is documented in docs/AI_USAGE.md across Claude Code (architecture/core logic), Antigravity (UI, art/audio assets, browser QA), and ChatGPT (tests/docs). Core creative direction and design decisions remain human-authored.

10. RISKS & MITIGATIONS

Identified Risk	Proactive Mitigation Strategy
Web Export / Browser Bugs	Tested every milestone via Playwright headless Chromium. Compatibility renderer enforced from Day 1.
Puzzles Unsolvable / Obscure	Automated headless level validator verifies solvability and move counts before authoring.
Scope Overrun	Strict 6-level cap, 15-minute loop target, hard feature freeze at Hour 85.